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and barrier nets. Preservation of prawns is done by peeling and deveining or by cooking and peeling.

13.7.3 Pearl Culture

Pearl is a white, highly shining globular concretion found within the shell of an Oyster. Pearl oysters are sedentary animals. In India it was cultured for the first time in 1973 at Thoothukudi. Pearl oysters are found along the coast of Kanyakumari and in the Gulf of Kutch. High quality pearls are obtained from pearl oysters of Genus *Pinctada* that can be cultured in the salinity range of 30 ppt in racks, raft and long line methods. Freshwater bivalve *Lamellidens* is also used in artificial pearl culture. Mostly the pearl oysters inhabit the ridges of rocks or dead corals, forming extensive pearl banks. These pearl beds produce best quality of pearls called as "Lingha Pearl".

Pearl Formation

When a foreign particle accidently enters into the space between mantle and shell of the oyster, it adheres to the mantle. The mantle epithelium encloses it like a sac and starts to secrete concentric layers of nacre around it as a defensive mechanism. Nacre is secreted continuously by the epithelial layer of the mantle and is deposited around the foreign particle and over a period time

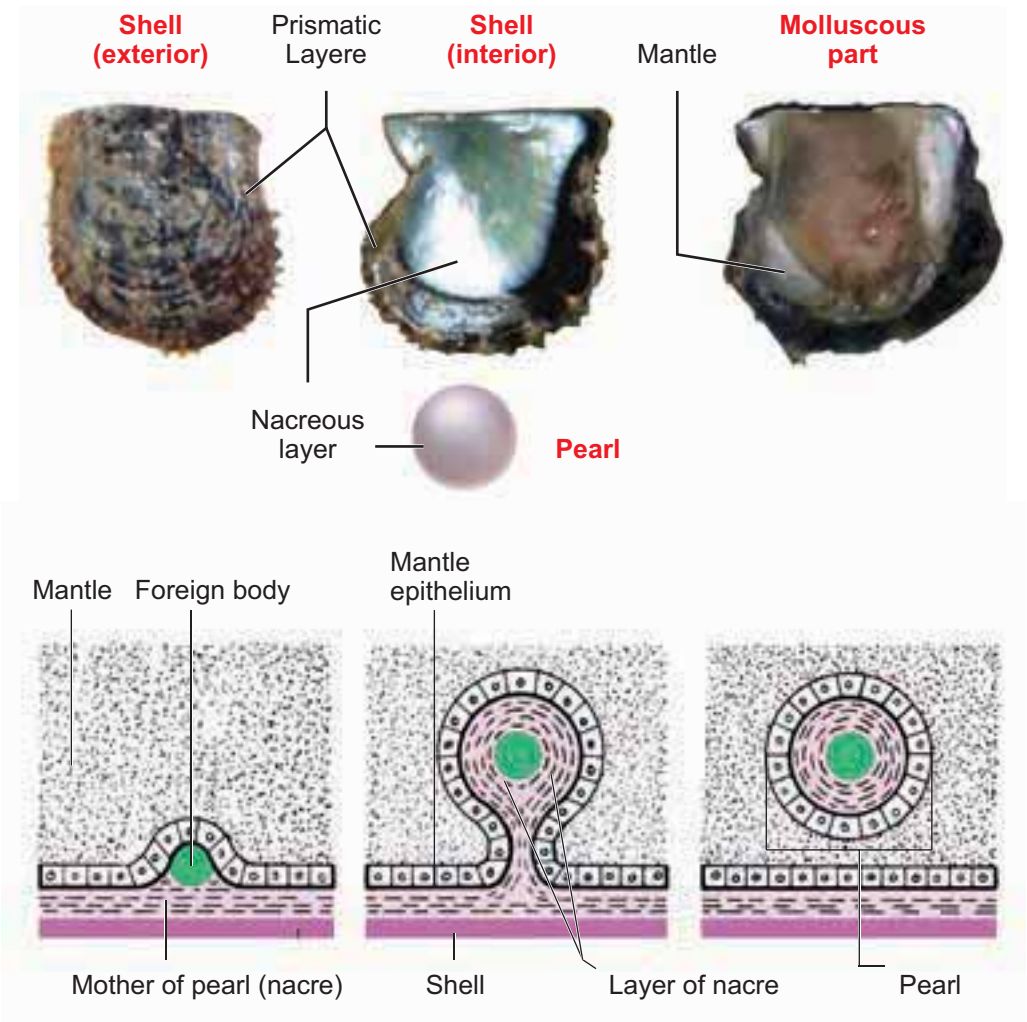


Figure 13. 12 Pearl and Pearl Formation